

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Part I: The Body / The Case Opens

THE EXORCISM OF EMILY ROSE

PROLOGUE: THE BARN

The cold in November didn't just sit on the skin; it burrowed. It found the gaps in your coat, the seams in your boots, the hollow spaces in your chest.

Maria Rose stood on the back porch of the farmhouse, her hands wrapped around a mug of coffee that had gone lukewarm ten minutes ago. She wasn't drinking it. She was just holding it, using the ceramic as a failing anchor against the wind.

The wind was screaming.

It came off the plains, tearing through the dead cornstalks, rattling the windows in their frames. It sounded like a thousand people whispering all at once, or maybe one person screaming from a very long way away.

Maria looked out at the barn.

It sat on the hill, a dark, hulking shape against the grey sky. The wood was black with rain. The roof was tin, and in the summer, it sang when the storms came.

Tonight, it was silent.

Too silent.

"Maria?"

She turned. Her husband, Nathaniel, was standing in the doorway. He looked older than he had a week ago. His face was grey, the lines around his mouth etched deep with a chisel of exhaustion. He was wearing his work coat, the canvas stained with oil and... something else.

Something dark and crusted.

"Is it over?" Maria asked. Her voice was small, a ghost of a sound.

Nathaniel didn't answer. He looked past her, towards the barn.

"The car is coming," he said. "The doctor."

Maria felt a shiver that had nothing to do with the wind.

"The doctor? But Father Moore said..."

"Father Moore is praying," Nathaniel said. He stepped out onto the porch, the boards creaking under his weight. He smelled of wet hay and ozone. "He's been praying for an hour. But she isn't moving, Maria."

Maria dropped the mug. It shattered on the porch, brown liquid splashing against her boots.

She didn't look down.

She ran.

The mud sucked at her boots, trying to hold her back, trying to keep her from the truth. The wind slapped her face, stinging her eyes.

The barn door was open a crack. A sliver of darkness.

Maria pushed it open.

The smell hit her first.

It wasn't the smell of animals. It wasn't the smell of hay.

It was the smell of a battery that had burst. Acrid. Metallic. Copper and sulfur and something sweet, like rotting lilies.

"Emily?" she whispered.

The inside of the barn was shadowed, lit only by a single lantern hanging from a beam. The light swung back and forth, casting long, dancing shadows on the walls.

Father Moore was kneeling by the cot. His black cassock was ruined, torn at the shoulder, stained with mud. His head was bowed. His hands were clasped so tightly the knuckles were white.

He was muttering.

"...requiem aeternam dona ei, Domine..."

Maria stopped. Her breath caught in her throat.

Emily was lying on the cot.

She looked... small.

So small.

Like a bird that had flown into a window.

Her arms were at her sides. Her legs were straight. The restraints—the leather straps they had been forced to use, God forgive them—were loose.

Her eyes were open.

They were staring up at the rafters.

But they weren't seeing the wood. They weren't seeing the lantern.

They were seeing something else. Something far away.

And they were still.

So terribly, perfectly still.

"No," Maria whispered.

Father Moore stopped praying. He didn't turn around. His shoulders slumped.

"I'm sorry, Maria," he said. His voice was a ruin. A broken thing. "We... we lost her."

Maria walked to the cot. She fell to her knees in the straw.

She reached out and touched Emily's hand.

It was cold.

Not just winter cold.

Stone cold.

"Emily," Maria said. She brushed a strand of hair from her daughter's forehead. The skin was bruised, purple and yellow, a map of the war that had been fought in this room. "Emily, baby. Wake up."

Emily didn't move.

But on her face...

Maria leaned closer.

There was something there.

Not fear.

Not pain.

A smile.

A faint, ghost of a smile. As if, in the final moment, the horror had broken, and she had seen something beautiful.

Then the sirens started.

Wailing in the distance, getting louder. The world was coming. The police. The coroner. The questions.

The Barn door banged open in the wind.

Snow began to drift in, settling on Emily's still face like a shroud.

Maria Rose closed her eyes and screamed.

But the wind took the sound and carried it away, leaving only the silence of the barn.

And the smell of sulfur, slowly fading into the cold.

PART I: THE BODY / THE CASE OPENS

CHAPTER 1: 3:00

The digital clock on the nightstand didn't tick. It just burned.

Red numbers in the dark.

2:59.

Erin Bruner watched it. She didn't want to. She wanted to be asleep. She **needed** to be asleep. Tomorrow was the Van Hopper verdict, and she needed to be sharp. She needed to be the "Iron Lady" the press loved to hate.

But her body wouldn't cooperate. Her muscles were tight, coiled like springs. Her mind was a hamster wheel of closing arguments and "what-ifs."

Did I emphasize the timeline enough? Did Juror 4 buy the doubt? Did Van Hopper look sad enough?

She rolled over, pulling the high-thread-count duvet up to her chin. The condo was silent. Thirty floors up, the city noise was just a hum, a vibration in the floorboards.

She closed her eyes.

Relax. Breathe. In for four, hold for four, out for four.

It was a technique her therapist had taught her. Before she fired the therapist for suggesting that Erin used work as an avoidance mechanism.

I don't avoid, Erin had told her. *I win.*

She opened her eyes.

The clock changed.

3:00.

Erin exhaled. Okay. Three a.m. The witching hour. The hour of the wolf. The hour where lonely people realized just how big their beds were.

She reached for the glass of water on the nightstand.

Her hand froze.

The air in the room had changed.

It wasn't a draft. A draft was movement. This was... heavy. Static.

Like the air before a thunderstorm, when the ions charge the atmosphere and the hair on your arms stands up.

But the sky outside was clear.

And the smell.

Erin sniffed.

It was faint, but distinct.

Something burning?

Toast?

No. Not toast.

It smelled like... old pennies. Copper.

And something underneath it. Something sweet and cloying. Like flowers left in a vase too long, until the water turns grey and slimy.

"Jasper?" she whispered.

Her Persian cat usually slept at the foot of the bed, a heavy, purring anchor.

Tonight, the bed was light.

Erin sat up. "Jasper?"

She looked towards the bedroom door. It was ajar.

A shadow moved in the hallway.

Just a shift in the darkness.

Erin's heart did a double-tap against her ribs.

Intruder.

The word was a splash of ice water.

She slid out of bed, her bare feet sinking into the carpet. She grabbed the heavy brass lamp from the table. It was a ludicrous weapon—a piece of "modern art" that looked like a twisted spine—but it was heavy.

She crept to the door.

The hallway was empty.

The living room beyond was bathed in the orange glow of the streetlights filtering through the floor-to-ceiling windows.

"Jasper?"

She found him.

He was standing on the back of the sofa, silhouetted against the city lights.

His back was arched. His fur was standing straight up, making him look twice his size.

He was hissing.

A low, guttural sound that vibrated in the room.

He wasn't looking at Erin.

He was looking at the corner. At the Eames lounge chair Erin's father had given her as a graduation present.

Erin looked at the chair.

It was empty.

The leather was distressed, worn soft by years of reading briefs and drinking wine.

But as she watched, the seat cushion... moved.

It depressed.

Slowly. Inch by inch.

As if a heavy weight was settling into it.

The leather creaked. *Eeeee.*

The sound of someone getting comfortable.

Erin stopped breathing.

She blinked.

It's a trick of the light. It's the shadows.

But the depression remained. A perfect, invisible mold of a person.

And the smell got stronger.

The copper taste filled her mouth.

"Who's there?" Erin said. Her voice was steady, but it wasn't her voice. It was a thin, reedy thing.

Silence.

Then, the depression in the cushion shifted.

It began to rise.

Slowly. Deliberately.

As if the occupant was standing up to greet her.

Erin didn't wait to see what happened next.

She turned and ran.

She bolted back into the bedroom, slamming the door and locking it. She dragged the heavy oak dresser in front of the door, her nails scratching against the wood.

She backed away, clutching the lamp to her chest like a crucifix.

She stared at the door handle.

It didn't turn.

Nothing pounded on the wood.

Silence returned to the condo.

But it wasn't the silence of emptiness.

It was the silence of *waiting*.

Erin looked at the clock.

3:00.

She frowned. It had been 3:00 for... how long? Ten minutes?

She watched the numbers.

They didn't change.

The colon didn't blink.

Time had stopped.

Or maybe... maybe she wasn't in time anymore.

She grabbed her wrist, feeling for her pulse. It was racing. *Thump-thump-thump.*

She looked at her wristwatch, which she had left on the dresser.

The second hand was twitching.

Stuck.

Ticking back and forth on the 12.

Tick-tick. Tick-tick.

Erin slid down the wall, pulling her knees to her chest.

"You're tired," she whispered. "You're stressed. It's Van Hopper. It's the guilt."

She said the word aloud, testing it.

Guilt.

Did she feel guilt?

She saved a murderer. She knew he was a murderer.

Was this... punishment?

No. She was a lawyer. She didn't believe in karma. She believed in evidence.

And there was no evidence here. Just a smell. Just a shadow.

Just a stopped clock.

She closed her eyes.

Wake up. Wake up.

When she opened them again, the clock blinked.

3:01.

The spell broke.

The air lightened. The smell faded, replaced by the scent of her own lavender laundry detergent.

Erin let out a breath she felt she had been holding for an hour.

She stood up, her legs shaky.

She moved the dresser back. She unlocked the door.

She looked into the hallway.

Empty.

Jasper trotted in, meowing, rubbing against her leg as if nothing had happened.

Erin picked him up, burying her face in his fur. He smelled like cat food and dust.

Real smells.

"You're okay," she whispered. "We're okay."

She walked to the living room.

The chair was empty. The cushion was smooth.

She walked to the window, looking out at the city.

It was raining now. A light drizzle slicking the glass.

She pressed her hand against the cool pane.

It was just a nightmare. A waking dream.

But as she turned to go back to bed, she saw it.

On the coffee table.

Her notebook.

She had left it closed.

Now, it was open.

And on the blank page, there was a drawing.

A crude, charcoal sketch.

Not charcoal.

Soot.

It was a picture of a face. screaming.

And under it, three words written in a jagged, violent hand.

WE ARE HERE.

Erin stared at it.

She touched the soot. It came away black on her finger.

She hadn't drawn it.

She lived alone.

She looked back at the empty chair.

And for the first time in her life, Erin Bruner was afraid to close her eyes.

CHAPTER 2: ARRAIGNMENT

The morning after the Van Hopper verdict, the sun didn't rise so much as the grey sky just got slightly brighter.

Erin drove to the office on autopilot. Her hands gripped the leather steering wheel of her Mercedes, her knuckles white. She had scrubbed the soot off her finger, but she could still feel it. A phantom stain.

She had burned the notebook page in the sink. Watched the face scream as it turned to ash.

Stress, she repeated. *Just stress.*

The firm was buzzing. The "Victory Lap" had turned into a "Victory March."

Paralegals smiled at her. Junior associates got out of her way.

Ray, her second chair on the Van Hopper case, was waiting by her office door.

"Boss," he said, grinning. "The press is calling. CNN wants a statement. The Times wants an interview."

"Tell them no comment," Erin said, unlocking her door.

Ray blinked. "No comment? Erin, you're the 'Giant Killer.' You should be taking a lap."

"I'm taking a coffee, Ray. And aspirin."

She went into her office and shut the door.

She leaned against it, closing her eyes.

The silence of the office was usually a comfort. Today, it felt oppressive.

She walked to her desk.

There was a file on it.

A red folder. *Urgent.*

A sticky note from Karl: *See me. Now.*

Erin dropped her bag and walked to the corner office.

Karl was on the phone, looking out at the city. He waved her in.

"I know," he was saying. "I know it's a disaster. We'll contain it."

He hung up.

He turned to Erin. He looked serious. Not the shark-smile serious. Real serious.

"Sit down."

Erin sat. "Who's the disaster?"

"The Archdiocese."

"The priest case?"

"Father Richard Moore. He was arraigned this morning. The judge denied bail."

"Denied bail? On a negligent homicide? That's aggressive."

"The judge is Brewster. He's up for re-election. He wants to look tough on... weirdness."

"Weirdness?"

"The DA... Ethan Thomas... he made a show of it. Called Moore a 'flight risk to the spiritual plane' or some nonsense. But it worked. Moore is in County. Solitary."

Karl slid the file across the desk.

"I need you to go down there. Now."

"To the jail?"

"To take the case."

Erin hesitated. "Karl, I just finished a six-month murder trial. I need a break."

"You need the Senior Partnership," Karl said softly. "And this is the price of admission."

He pointed to the file.

"If you win this... if you save the Church from a hundred-million-dollar liability suit... you can write your own ticket. You can have my job when I retire."

"And if I lose?"

"Don't lose."

The County Jail was a different world from the glass tower of the firm. It was a world of concrete, steel, and fluorescent lights that buzzed like trapped flies.

Erin hated it.

She hated the smell—bleach and body odor. She hated the metal detectors. She hated the way the guards looked at her legs.

She checked in at the front desk.

"Attorney visit for Moore," she said.

The guard, a heavy-set woman named Officer Higgins, looked up.

"The Exorcist guy?"

"Father Moore."

"Yeah. He's in D Block. Watch yourself, honey. He's spooky."

Erin walked down the long corridor to D Block.

The air got colder as she went deeper into the facility.

She passed the communal cells. Usually, the inmates catcalled her.

Today, they were silent.

They watched her pass with dark, hooded eyes.

Some of them made signs. Hand gestures. Warding off evil? Or inviting it?

Erin kept her eyes forward. *Click-clack. Click-clack.*

She reached the interview room.

The guard unlocked the heavy steel door.

"He's in there. Good luck."

Erin stepped inside.

The room was small, windowless. A metal table bolted to the floor. Two chairs.

Father Richard Moore sat in the far chair.

He was wearing his clerical collar, but his shirt was wrinkled. He looked thin. Gaunt.

But it was his stillness that struck her.

He wasn't fidgeting. He wasn't pacing. He sat with his hands folded on the table, perfectly motionless. Like a statue carved from grey stone.

He didn't look up when she entered.

"Father Moore?"

He slowly raised his head.

His eyes.

Erin had seen a lot of eyes. Killers, liars, victims.

Moore's eyes were different.

They were deep. Infinite. And terrified.

Not terrified of her. Terrified of what he had seen.

"I'm Erin Bruner," she said, setting her briefcase down. "I'm your attorney."

Moore looked at the briefcase. Then at her.

"You're the one," he said. His voice was rough, unused.

"The one?"

"The one they sent."

"The Archdiocese sent me. Yes."

"Not the Archdiocese," Moore whispered.

He leaned forward. The chains on his wrists rattled.

"Do you believe in the Devil, Ms. Bruner?"

Erin paused. It was the standard question.

"I believe in the Constitution, Father. And I believe in the Rules of Evidence."

Moore smiled. It was a sad, broken smile.

"That's a pity," he said. "Because the Devil believes in you."

Erin felt a chill run down her spine. The same copper taste filled her mouth.

"Let's focus on the case," she said, opening her notebook. "Ethan Thomas is charging you with negligent homicide. He says you told Emily Rose to stop her medication."

"I told her to trust God."

"In the eyes of the law, that's the same thing as negligence."

"Then the law is blind."

"The law is a tool, Father. And right now, it's a tool being used to crush you. I can stop that. But you have to work with me. You have to tell me exactly what happened in that barn."

Moore looked away. He looked at the two-way mirror.

"The barn," he whispered.

"Yes. The night she died."

"She didn't die," Moore said. "She was released."

"Father..."

"You want to know what happened?" Moore looked back at her. His intensity was physically palpable, like heat radiating from a furnace. "We opened a door. And something came through. Something that had been waiting a long time."

"Something?"

"We are Legion," Moore quoted. "For we are many."

Erin wrote it down. *Client delusional? Religious fixation.*

But her hand shook.

"We'll enter a plea of Not Guilty," she said. "We'll argue... alternative causality."

"You can argue whatever you want," Moore said. "But be warned, Erin Bruner."

"Warned of what?"

Moore reached out. He touched her hand. His skin was ice cold.

"Once you look at the darkness," he whispered. "The darkness looks back. It knows your name now."

Erin pulled her hand away.

"I'm a lawyer, Father. I deal in facts."

"Then here is a fact," Moore said. "It's 3:00 AM. Do you know why you wake up at 3:00 AM?"

Erin froze.

How did he know?

"It's the mocking of the Trinity," Moore said softly. "The inverse of 3:00 PM. The miracle hour. The hour of death. The hour when the veil is thinnest."

Erin stood up. She packed her bag. She needed to get out of there. The air in the room was suffocating.

"I'll... I'll see you at the bail hearing."

She knocked on the door. "Guard!"

As the door opened, she looked back.

Moore was back in his statue pose. Staring at his hands.

"Pray," he whispered. "Pray for protection."

Erin walked out into the corridor.

She walked fast.

She didn't look at the inmates.

She got to the lobby and burst out into the rain.

She took a deep breath of the wet, smoggy air.

He's crazy, she told herself. *He's just a crazy priest.*

But she looked at her watch.

The second hand was moving.

Tick-tick.

She got in her car.

She looked in the rearview mirror.

Her eyes looked tired. Scared.

"Get a grip," she said aloud.

But she knew.

The game had changed.

This wasn't Van Hopper. This wasn't a murder trial.

This was something else.

And she was already in deep water.